

Skills Summary

Division Three Ways

Use this reference while completing your worksheet or when studying.

Skill 1 — From a story to an equation

Rule: Find the *total* first — it always comes before the $\div$ sign.

Then divide by the number the story gives: the groups, or the number in each group.

Example: 14 carrots are shared equally by 2 rabbits. Write the equation and solve.

Step 1. The total is 14 and there are 2 equal groups, so the equation is $14 \div 2$.

Step 2. $14 \div 2 = 7$, because $2 \times 7 = 14$.

$\Rightarrow$ 7 carrots each

Try it: 25 grapes are shared equally onto 5 plates. Write the equation and solve.

check: $5 \times 5 = 25$

Skill 2 — From a drawing to an equation

Rule: Count all the dots (the total), then count the groups.

$\text{total} \div \text{groups} = \text{dots in each group}$.

Example: A drawing shows 12 dots in 3 equal rings. Write the equation it shows.

Step 1. The whole drawing holds 12 dots split into 3 equal rings, so it shows $12 \div 3$.

Step 2. Each ring holds $12 \div 3 = 4$ dots — count one ring to check.

$\Rightarrow$ 4 dots in each ring

Try it: A drawing shows 18 dots in 2 equal groups. What equation does it show, and how many dots are in each group?

check: $9 \times 2 = 18$

Skill 3 — From an equation to a story

Rule: For $\text{total} \div \text{number}$: pick objects for the *total*, then decide what the second number is — how many groups, or how many in each group.

End your story with a question the quotient answers.

Example: Write a story for $15 \div 3$ and solve it.

Step 1. Pick 15 objects and make the 3 a number of groups: “15 shells are shared equally into 3 buckets — how many in each?”

Step 2. $15 \div 3 = 5$, because $3 \times 5 = 15$.

$\Rightarrow$ 5 shells in each bucket

Try it: Write your own story for $20 \div 4$, then solve it.

check: $5 \times 4 = 20$

(!) Watch out: The total always comes *first* in a division equation. A drawing of 24 dots in 4 groups shows $24 \div 4$, never $4 \div 24$.